Copilot, OpenCode, and Kiro Side by Side

GitHub Copilot as a Coding-Agent Harness

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Agenda

- Three harnesses at a glance
- Models and where they run
- Context: instruction files and MCP
- Approvals, sandboxing, and the path to a pull request
- What's open source
- Where Copilot stands out, and where it's constrained

Three Harnesses at a Glance

	Copilot	OpenCode	Kiro
Maker	GitHub	Anomaly	AWS
Surfaces	VS Code, CLI, app, GitHub.com	Terminal UI, desktop, web	IDE, CLI, Web, Mobile
Terminal command	`copilot`	`opencode` (v1 and v2)	`kiro-cli`
Windows install	WinGet `GitHub.Copilot`	Binary or npm	PowerShell script

- Same loop in all three: model, tools, approvals, session state

Models and Where They Run

	Copilot	OpenCode	Kiro
Model list	GitHub's: 6 vendors + Auto	Any provider	Kiro's, by credit multiplier
Your key, or local	BYOK in VS Code, CLI, app	Yes, incl. Ollama	Not documented
Hosting	Vendor clouds, GitHub's Azure	Your provider or machine	AWS, US and EU regions
Billing	AI Credits, token-metered	Your provider's bill	Monthly credits by tier

Context: Instructions and MCP

	Copilot	OpenCode 2	Kiro
Instructions	`copilot-instructions.md` and more	`AGENTS.md` only	`.kiro/steering/*.md`
`AGENTS.md`	Read; nearest wins	The only file	Always included
Custom agents	`.github/agents/`	`.opencode/agents/`	`.kiro/agents/`
MCP file	`.mcp.json`	`opencode.json`	`.kiro/settings/mcp.json`
MCP key	`mcpServers`	`mcp.servers`	`mcpServers`

- `AGENTS.md` is the one file all three read

Approvals, Sandbox, and the PR

	Copilot	OpenCode	Kiro
Approvals	Prompts, allow/deny, modes	allow / ask / deny rules	Autopilot or Supervised; rules
Local sandbox	Yes, off by default	None	Yes, off by default
Task to PR	Assign issue → draft PR	Local `git` and `gh`	`kiro` label or `/kiro`
Cloud runs	Actions or cloud sandbox	Action removed in v2.2.0	Kiro Web sandbox

What's Open Source

	Open source	Not open source
Copilot	VS Code + chat, SDK, MCP server	CLI, app, cloud agent, models
OpenCode	The whole agent (MIT)	Console, Go, Models
Kiro	Kiro Crew (Apache-2.0)	IDE, CLI, Web

Where Copilot Stands Out

- One harness from VS Code to the terminal to GitHub.com
- Issue to draft PR with CodeQL, secret and dependency checks
- Copilot code review as a built-in second opinion
- Six model vendors and Auto from one subscription
- Same instructions, agents, and MCP config across surfaces
- Org policy and MCP allowlists enforced in app, CLI, VS Code

Where Copilot Is Constrained

- Cloud agent: GitHub-hosted repositories only
- Actions sessions: one repo, 59-minute cap (issue assignment too)
- Cloud sandboxes span one org's repos, but skip setup steps
- One branch and one pull request per task
- Model menu set by GitHub; no BYOK in the cloud agent
- CLI, app, and agent services are proprietary
- Two meters: AI Credits plus Actions compute

Choosing for Your Team

- Copilot: code on GitHub; want issue to PR with checks built in
- OpenCode: need open source, any provider, or local models
- Kiro: spec-driven work, AWS hosting, or GitLab for cloud work
- OpenCode has no sandbox; Copilot's and Kiro's are off by default
- Keep conventions in `AGENTS.md` to stay portable

Key Takeaways

- All three run the same loop: model, tools, approvals
- They differ in who picks the model and where it runs
- `AGENTS.md` is the portable instruction file
- Copilot's edge is GitHub itself: issues, PRs, checks, review
- Its limits: GitHub-hosted repos, GitHub's menu, closed services